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Post-COVID Consumer Behaviour in the UK Fashion Market: A Study of Online vs Offline Shopping Preferences and Strategic Implications for Retailers

ABSTRACT

This dissertation investigates consumer behaviour in UK fashion retail, focusing on shopping channel preferences, generational and gender differences, sustainability attitudes, and perceptions of ultra-fast fashion. A quantitative survey was conducted using Qualtrics, yielding 137 valid responses from UK residents. Data were analysed through descriptive statistics, correlation tests, t-tests, repeated-measures ANOVAs, and regression models in SPSS(29). The results indicate a slight preference for offline purchasing; nonetheless, omnichannel behaviour dominates, since the majority of customers interact with both online and offline platforms. Gender differences were evident with women valuing experience and social dimensions of buying, whilst men focused on cost. Generational comparisons, limited by a biased dataset, revealed no substantial changes. Attitudes towards sustainability and criticism of fast fashion significantly influenced offline preferences and perceptions of enhanced sustainability in in-person buying. This study enhances comprehension of the changing UK retail environment, emphasising its significance for theoretical frameworks, retail strategies, and ethical fashion practices.

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background and Context

The COVID-19 pandemic significantly changed consumer behaviour across various industries, with the fashion sector being one of the most impacted. Lockdowns, social distancing protocols, and the temporary shutdown of physical retail establishments compelled consumers to depend significantly on e-commerce platforms to fulfil their fashion requirements (Pantano et al., 2020; Sheth, 2020). What was originally perceived as a temporary disturbance has instead expedited a structural transition in the UK retail fashion sector, raising essential enquiries over the stability of these behavioural changes.

Historically, the UK fashion market was defined by a strong high-street retail presence, supported by an expanding e-commerce sector. Nevertheless, the balance between these two channels has significantly changed since the pandemic. Currently, customers explore a complex environment where convenience, digital proficiency, experience worth, and sustainability issues converge to influence purchasing decisions (ONS, 2024).(ONS, 2024). This environment has fostered the emergence of the "hybrid shopper," who seamlessly navigates between online and offline platforms based on situational requirements, exemplifying the progressively multichannel character of consumer behaviour (Verhoef, Kannan & Inman, 2017).

Simultaneously, predominant consumer values have evolved. Particularly, younger generations exhibit greater digital fluency, heightened responsiveness to online marketing, and increased familiarity with app-based buying experiences (Djafarova & Trofimenko, 2019). Whereas, older consumers frequently maintain an appreciation for the physical and social dimensions of in-store shopping, while being necessitated to embrace digital platforms

throughout the epidemic (Magrath & McCormick, 2013). Simultaneously, predominant consumer values have evolved. Younger generations have superior digital fluency, enhanced response to online marketing, and more familiarity with app-based purchasing experiences (Djafarova & Trofimenko, 2019). In contrast, elderly customers often retain a fondness for the tangible and social aspects of in-store buying, while being compelled to use digital platforms during the pandemic (Magrath & McCormick, 2013). Generational inequalities significantly impact merchants seeking to develop channel strategies that resonate with diverse demographic groupings.

A vital aspect influencing fashion consumption is sustainability. The fast fashion model, characterised by swift production cycles, minimal costs, and frequent turnover, has faced extensive criticism for its environmental and ethical deficiencies (Joy et al., 2012; Niinimäki et al., 2020). Heightened consumer knowledge of these matters has amplified the demand for ethically sourced and environmentally sustainable fashion, impacting both product selections and shopping channel preferences (Jones & Comfort, 2020). The emergence of resale and second-hand platforms in the UK underscores a transition towards circular fashion practices (Vogue Business, 2024). This signifies that consumer expectations now encompass not only convenience and affordability but also social responsibility. Moreover, mid-market retailers previously dominant in the UK fashion industry are experiencing escalating pressure. Traditional high-street stores have had challenges in remaining relevant, caught between the low-cost supremacy of quick fashion e-tailers and the premium appeal of sustainability-focused labels (Forbes, 2025). The evolving landscape has heightened competitiveness and transformed consumer decision-making in ways that remain incompletely comprehended, especially in the post-COVID context.

1.2 Research Problem

The epidemic increased online adoption while revealing substantial structural problems in the UK fashion retail sector. Recent studies often focus on the initial epidemic phase (2020–2021), characterised by variable consumer behaviours, or take a global perspective that overlooks specific attributes of the UK. The UK's unique reliance on high-street culture, combined with its dominance in fast fashion and the emergence of environmental initiatives, requires a focused analysis of consumer behaviour in a post-COVID context (ONS, 2024). Despite considerable discussion regarding the evolution of fashion consumption, empirical evidence examining UK-specific consumer behaviour in the fashion market post-2022 is limited. Examines differences in channel preferences across generations, and analyses the influence of sustainability factors on both online and offline purchasing decisions. This disparity constrains academic understanding and retail strategy. Without comprehensive and current UK-specific data, merchants risk misinterpreting customer preferences, thereby undermining their competitive effectiveness in a fragmented and evolving market.

1.3 Research Aim

This dissertation aims to examine how UK consumers' fashion shopping preferences between online and offline shopping have evolved in the UK after the COVID-19 pandemic, especially considering increasing competition from fast fashion e-tailers and the decreasing appeal of traditional mid-market retail, with attention to age group differences and sustainability considerations.

1.4 Research Objective

The study aims to achieve the following objectives:

1. To examine current consumer preferences for online vs offline fashion shopping in the UK post-COVID.
2. To analyse how shopping preferences differ across various age groups (e.g., Generation Z, Millennials, Gen X, Boomers).
3. To identify the key factors that influence channel preference (e.g., convenience, price, experience).
4. To evaluate how sustainability concerns impact consumer decisions in online vs offline fashion shopping.

1.5 Research Questions

1. What are the current preferences of UK consumers for purchasing fashion products online versus in-store in the post-COVID period?
2. How do fashion shopping channel preferences (online vs offline) vary among different age groups in the UK?
3. What factors influence UK consumers' choice of channel when purchasing fashion items?
4. To what extent do sustainability concerns to UK fashion consumers in their choice of shopping channel (Online or offline)?

1.6 Significance of the Research

This study enhances the existing literature on post-pandemic consumer behaviour by providing new insights into the UK fashion industry. By concentrating on channel preferences, generational disparities, and sustainability issues, it offers a detailed comprehension of the evolution of consumer behaviour in reaction to fundamental market transformations. The insights will assist shops in enhancing their strategic posture. For high-street and mid-market brands facing pressure, understanding consumer expectations may guide the formulation of effective omnichannel strategies and sustainability initiatives. The study provides information regarding how customers evaluate cost, convenience, experience, and ethics when choosing purchasing channels for quick fashion and premium goods. The study fills significant gaps in the literature by offering UK-specific, post-2022, quantitative evidence from an academic standpoint. It enhances comprehension of the complex interactions of demographic, behavioural, and ethical elements influencing consumer decision-making in the fashion sector.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Consumer Behaviour Theories and Fashion Shopping

Understanding consumer behaviour in fashion retail requires engagement with theoretical frameworks that explain why individuals adopt particular shopping channels and practices. Two of the most widely applied models are the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB), while complementary perspectives such as the Diffusion of Innovations (DOI), Consumer Culture Theory (CCT), and

more recent contributions such as Self-Determination Theory (SDT) and the Experiential Consumption perspective also offer valuable insights.

The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), introduced by Davis (1989), argues that consumers' adoption of new technologies is primarily determined by their perceptions of usefulness and ease of use. In fashion retail, TAM has been applied to the uptake of e-commerce platforms, mobile shopping applications, and digital payment systems. Research shows that consumers who perceive online shopping as efficient, intuitive, and time-saving are more likely to integrate it into their shopping routines (Gefen, Karahanna and Straub, 2003). Whereas perceptions of risk, complexity, or lack of trust discourage adoption. Trust has been found to moderate the relationship between perceived ease of use and purchase intentions, with consumers requiring assurance on payment security, delivery reliability, and product authenticity before committing to online transactions (Kim, Ferrin and Rao, 2009). TAM thus helps explain why younger, digitally fluent generations adopt online fashion channels more readily than older groups, who often face greater technological and trust barriers. The Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB), developed by Ajzen (1991), expands the explanatory scope by emphasising three determinants of behaviour: attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control. In fashion retail, attitudes may reflect consumer beliefs about sustainability, affordability, or convenience. Subjective norms capture the influence of peers, cultural expectations, or social media. Perceived behavioural control relates to access to technology, disposable income, or confidence in navigating platforms. For example, a consumer who values sustainability may still purchase fast fashion if affordability and social pressures outweigh ethical attitudes (Han and Stoel, 2017). TPB is therefore particularly relevant to understanding the persistent "attitude-behaviour gap" in fashion, where pro-sustainability values often fail to translate into actual purchase decisions.

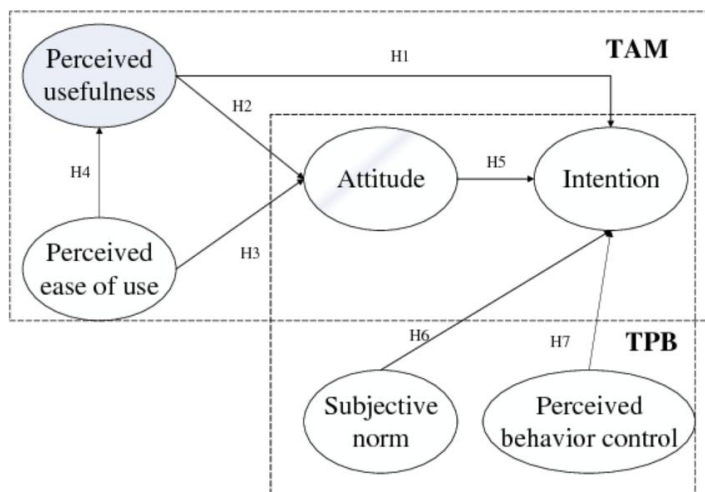


Figure 1. The Theory of Planned Behaviour and The Technology Acceptance Model

The Diffusion of Innovations (DOI) theory provides an additional layer by explaining how new technologies spread through society (Rogers, 2003). In fashion retail, this model is useful for understanding the adoption of innovations such as virtual fitting rooms, resale platforms. Generation Z and Millennials often act as innovators, while older generations adopt only when technologies become mainstream. This helps examine the uneven pace of digital adoption across age groups. From a cultural standpoint, Consumer Culture Theory (CCT) frames consumption not merely as functional but as a means of identity construction and cultural participation (Arnould

and Thompson, 2005). Fashion is particularly intertwined with identity, and online platforms have amplified opportunities for consumers to express and perform identity through curated digital content, peer validation, and participation in trend cycles. Similarly, the Experiential Consumption perspective emphasises that shopping is increasingly valued as an experience rather than just a practical act (Holbrook and Hirschman, 1982). This highlights the enduring appeal of physical stores for sensory and social events, even in a digital-first environment.

Finally, Self-Determination Theory (SDT) adds nuance by focusing on intrinsic and extrinsic motivations. Consumers may be intrinsically motivated to shop sustainably for personal satisfaction or ethical reasons, or extrinsically motivated by social recognition, peer influence, or price incentives (Deci and Ryan, 2000). This interplay between motivations aligns with TPB's emphasis on norms and attitudes, helping to explain why sustainable intentions often compete with price sensitivity in fast fashion. Thus, these ideas offer a multifaceted view of fashion retail customer behaviour. TAM emphasises technical adoption factors, TPB attitudes and social pressures, DOI contextualises new practice dissemination across demographics, CCT and experience views make purchasing identity-driven, and SDT explains reasons. Their integration provides a solid platform for studying how customers navigate online and offline channels, age and gender disparities, and why sustainability objectives sometimes conflict with buying behaviour.

2.2 Retail Channel Preferences: Online and Offline

The evolution of retail channel preferences has been a defining transformation in the fashion industry over the past decade. The relative appeal of online versus offline channels reflects not only functional considerations such as convenience or product evaluation but also psychological drivers such as trust, perceived risk, and experiential value. A balanced understanding of both perspectives is crucial to evaluating how consumers make channel decisions in fashion. Between 2015 and 2019, physical retail remained the dominant mode in the UK. Consumers valued the sensory engagement and social aspects of it. Fashion is a category where the ability to touch fabrics, try on garments, and receive face-to-face service has traditionally been central to the shopping experience (Dennis et al., 2010; Grewal, Levy and Kumar, 2009). Trust was also a key factor. Brick-and-mortar stores were associated with higher reliability in terms of product quality, secure transactions, and straightforward returns (Kerin, Jain and Howard, 2007). This explains why older generations and less tech-savvy shoppers continued to favour offline channels during this period.

Nevertheless, online retail steadily expanded throughout the 2010s. E-commerce offered consumers functional advantages such as a wider range, price comparison tools, and time-saving convenience (Chu and Liu, 2007). By 2019, online sales accounted for almost 20% of UK apparel purchases (Statista, 2019). This growth was strongly driven by younger, digitally literate consumers who viewed online platforms not only as efficient but also as socially embedded, with peer reviews, influencer marketing, and recommendation algorithms shaping purchase behaviour (Verhoef, Kannan and Inman, 2017). From 2020 onwards, the adoption of online shopping accelerated sharply, becoming normalised among broader demographics (Pantano et al., 2020). Data from the Office for National Statistics (2024) shows that online sales have increased than before, indicating that behavioural shifts have started. The appeal of online shopping now extends beyond efficiency, convenience, and social media influence that drive fashion discovery. Still, offline retail has not become obsolete. In fact, physical shopping continues to hold enduring advantages, particularly for high-value or occasion-based purchases where

tactile evaluation is essential. Research highlights the importance of hedonic and experiential value in-store, including atmosphere, customer service, and social interaction, all of which online platforms struggle to replicate (Vladimirova et al., 2022). Moreover, stores offer immediate ownership of goods, reducing the delay and uncertainty associated with delivery, which can remain a barrier for consumers sceptical of e-commerce.

Both channels also present limitations. Online shopping is associated with high return rates, particularly in fashion, where sizing and fit are difficult to standardise across brands. This creates financial and environmental costs, as reverse logistics increase carbon emissions and waste (Jones and Comfort, 2020). Security concerns and data privacy are further obstacles, particularly for older or risk-averse consumers. However, offline shopping involves its own sustainability drawbacks. Retail outlets are energy-intensive, and consumer travel to stores contributes significantly to carbon emissions (Vermeir and Verbeke, 2006). In short, retail channel preferences play a functional part in terms of benefits, trust, and sustainability concerns. While online shopping has grown rapidly due to its convenience and integration with digital lifestyles, offline shopping remains valued for its sensory and social dimensions. The coexistence of both channels underlines the need for research that explores not only the functional trade-offs but also the psychological and cultural dynamics shaping consumer decision-making in the UK fashion market.

2.3 Hybrid and Omnichannel Shopping

The distinction between online and offline retail channels has become increasingly blurred, giving rise to hybrid and omnichannel shopping models. Omnichannel retailing allows consumers to interact with brands across multiple touchpoints, moving fluidly between online and offline platforms. This development reflects both consumer expectations for convenience and consistency and retailer strategies to remain competitive in a dynamic market (Beck and Rygl, 2015). Early research on omnichannel retail emphasised its potential to provide a seamless customer experience and to integrate the advantages of both channels (Lazaris and Vrechopoulos, 2014). Nowadays, omnichannel shopping has become not only a competitive advantage but also a consumer expectation. Many shoppers engage in “research online, purchase offline” (ROPO) behaviour, or the reverse, depending on the product type and situational factors (Verhoef, Kannan and Inman, 2017). In fashion, consumers may browse collections on apps or websites before visiting physical stores to confirm fit and quality, or conversely, use stores for inspiration and then buy online for convenience or discounts. From a retailer perspective, omnichannel strategies are increasingly central to business models. Global fast-fashion leaders such as Zara and H&M have pioneered click-and-collect services, mobile apps with real-time inventory visibility, and integrated loyalty schemes (Gheorghe and Matefi, 2021). Marks & Spencer in the UK has also invested heavily in digital transformation, creating a more seamless integration between its online platform and physical outlets (Marks & Spencer, 2023). Such efforts show that modern consumers no longer view online and offline channels as distinct but expect retailers to deliver a consistent brand experience across both.

Consumers benefit from Omnichannel models as they maximise flexibility, enabling consumers to choose the most convenient path to purchase depending on context (Vogue Business, 2024). Furthermore, loyalty schemes and personalised recommendations, often powered by data analytics, increase engagement and repeat purchasing. However, omnichannel retailing is not without challenges. One major consumer frustration is inconsistency across platforms. For example, discrepancies in product availability or pricing between online and offline channels can undermine trust (Herhausen et al., 2015), and the returns policy is complex. While

omnichannel systems offer more options, they also increase logistical costs and often generate consumer confusion about policies. Additionally, privacy concerns are growing as retailers track consumer data across platforms to deliver personalised experiences (Jones and Comfort, 2020). Even in terms of sustainability, it raises a few concerns. Flexible returns and same-day delivery may be convenient but contribute significantly to carbon emissions and packaging waste (Niinimäki et al., 2020). Research has only recently begun to examine how consumer demand for convenience interacts with sustainability values, particularly in the UK fashion market. Despite these drawbacks, omnichannel retailing is widely recognised as the future of fashion retail. The UK market, however, lacks extensive consumer-focused studies on omnichannel behaviour, with most academic research concentrating on retailer strategies. There is a gap in understanding how different demographics—such as generations or genders, adopt hybrid shopping and how sustainability considerations influence their channel use. Addressing this gap is crucial for both academic insight and industry practice, as successful omnichannel strategies require alignment not only with retailer efficiency but also with consumer motivations and values.

2.4 Generational Differences in Fashion Shopping

Generational groups provide an important lens for understanding differences in fashion shopping behaviour, particularly in relation to channel preferences, sustainability attitudes, and engagement with technology. However, the literature also warns against overgeneralisation, as some observed differences may reflect life stage effects rather than fixed generational traits (Eastman and Liu, 2012). Within the UK, empirical research remains relatively limited, with most studies focusing on specific generations in isolation rather than direct comparisons across groups. Nonetheless, insights from both academic studies and industry reports highlight meaningful distinctions between Generation Z, Millennials, Generation X, and Baby Boomers.

Generation Z (born roughly between 1997 and 2012) is often described as the first truly digital-native generation, growing up with smartphones, social media, and on-demand content (Turner, 2015). Their shopping behaviour reflects high digital fluency. Fashion browsing and purchase decisions are often shaped by social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram, where influencers drive rapid trend cycles (Djafarova and Trofimenko, 2019; Siregar et al., 2023). This generation also demonstrates a desire for affordability and fast trend adoption, making them frequent customers of fast-fashion and ultra-fast fashion retailers (Šimek, 2024). At the same time, they articulate pro-sustainability values, particularly in relation to climate change, though their actual consumption patterns often reveal a tension between affordability and ethics (Niinimäki et al., 2020). Whereas, Millennials (born 1981–1996) share some similarities with Generation Z in their comfort with digital channels, they exhibit more value-conscious and sustainability-oriented behaviour. Having experienced the 2008 financial crisis, Millennials are often portrayed as more pragmatic consumers, balancing price considerations with quality and ethical concerns (Fromm and Garton, 2013). Research indicates that Millennials are more likely than Generation Z to experiment with sustainable alternatives, such as resale platforms (e.g., Depop, Vinted) and rental services, while still engaging with fast fashion for affordability and convenience (Vogue Business, 2024). For UK retailers, Millennials represent an important bridge group, digitally literate but still engaged with physical stores, particularly for family or workwear purchases. Generation X (born 1965–1980) grew up with brick-and-mortar retail as the dominant channel and tends to retain a strong preference for in-store shopping. This generation values service quality, brand reputation, and the ability to physically inspect garments before purchase (Magrath and McCormick, 2013). However, over the past decade, Generation X has increasingly

adopted e-commerce, particularly for its convenience and time efficiency, as work and family responsibilities limit leisure time (Emerald, 2022). Unlike younger groups, however, their adoption of online fashion tends to be more functional and less socially driven, with less reliance on peer reviews or social media influencers. Also, Baby Boomers (born 1946–1964) represent the oldest consumer segment and historically have shown the lowest engagement with digital shopping channels. They often perceive higher risk in online transactions and report lower confidence with technology (Hale, 2019). Nonetheless, in the UK, Baby Boomers have become a growing presence in online retail since 2020, particularly due to necessity and convenience (ONS, 2024). Still, offline retail retains enduring appeal for this group, who value face-to-face service, tactile product evaluation, and social interaction in shopping. Despite these differences, some experts advise against assigning actions to generation. Eastman and Liu (2012) claim that life stage, discretionary income, and family status affect consumption more than generational identity. The fact that Millennials prioritise sustainability may be due to their age and life stage, since older customers value quality and reliability while younger consumers value identity-expressive consumption. Inside-generation diversity can be significant, as gender, class, and culture influence consumer behaviour throughout age.

While incomplete, age gaps offer important insights into UK fashion buying. Generation Z is the most technologically immersed and trend-driven generation, millennials balance digital literacy with sustainability, Gen X balances offline loyalty with online practicality, and baby boomers are more conventional but are using digital technologies. The lack of UK-specific, comparative studies highlights the need for research on how these generational groups view online versus offline shopping, sustainability, and fast fashion, and how these differences may affect the retail market's long-term evolution.

2.5 Gendered Patterns in Fashion Consumption

Gender remains a central determinant of fashion shopping behaviour, shaping motivations, preferences, and channel choices. Decades of research have consistently highlighted differences between men and women in terms of their relationship with fashion, but recent studies also reveal how these patterns are evolving, particularly in digital contexts and sustainability engagement. Historically, women have been more involved in fashion consumption, engaging with clothing as a means of identity expression, variety-seeking, and social interaction (Bakewell and Mitchell, 2006). Fashion has often been framed as a cultural domain where femininity and consumption intersect, with women expected to be more fashion-conscious and responsive to trends (Crane, 2000). Women also demonstrate higher emotional engagement with shopping, often perceiving it as both a functional task and a leisure activity (O’Cass, 2004). However, men’s fashion consumption has always been more practical, with male consumers prioritising efficiency, functionality, and minimisation of time spent shopping (O’Cass, 2004). These gendered tendencies have also been reflected in channel preferences. Women were among the earliest adopters of online fashion shopping, motivated by the convenience and comparing products across retailers (Kim and Kim, 2004). However, women have also been more critical of online shopping limitations, particularly in relation to sizing accuracy, garment quality, and return policies (Hwang and Jeong, 2016). Men’s engagement with online fashion has historically been slower, yet the last decade has seen a notable increase in male participation, especially in categories such as sportswear, streetwear, and luxury goods (Forbes, 2023). This shift is partly driven by the growth of digital-first fashion brands targeting men, the rise of

sneaker culture, and the influence of online communities where male consumers increasingly engage with fashion identity.

Gender differences are also visible in relation to sustainability and ethical consumption. Research shows that women are more likely to report concern for environmental and ethical issues in fashion (Niinimäki et al., 2020). Men, by contrast, often demonstrate lower levels of sustainability engagement in fashion, with decisions more strongly influenced by convenience and price (Connell and Kozar, 2012). That said, younger men are beginning to engage more actively with sustainable and resale platforms such as Depop and Grailed, reflecting a gradual cultural shift. It is important to note that gender does not operate in isolation. Intersectional factors such as age, income, and cultural background shape how men and women engage with fashion. For example, younger women may prioritise affordability and trends through ultra-fast fashion, while older women may emphasise durability and quality. Similarly, men in higher-income brackets have been found to engage with luxury online retail at growing rates, challenging stereotypes of male disinterest in fashion (Okonkwo, 2007). Despite these insights, there remains a shortage of research directly integrating gender into the analysis of UK fashion retail behaviour. Much of the existing literature is either dated or focused on global rather than national contexts. Moreover, few studies explore how gender interacts with generational differences, hybrid shopping behaviours, or sustainability attitudes. Addressing these gaps is critical to understanding not only the persistence of gendered fashion practices but also how they are evolving in the context of online and omnichannel retail.

2.6 Sustainability, Fast Fashion, and Ethical Concerns

Sustainability has become an important subject of debate around fashion retail. The industry is repeatedly described as one of the most polluting in the world, responsible for enormous levels of carbon emissions, water use, and textile waste (Niinimäki et al., 2020). Shoppers are increasingly aware of these issues, yet research continues to highlight a persistent attitude–behaviour gap. In practice, many consumers still make their choices based on price, convenience, and the appeal of new styles, even when they openly express concern for the environment (Vermeir and Verbeke, 2006). This contradiction is particularly visible in the UK, where despite rising interest in second-hand and rental platforms such as Depop, Vinted, and Vestiaire Collective (Mintel, 2024), fast-fashion retailers remain firmly at the centre of the market. One of the challenges lies in the way different shopping channels shape sustainability outcomes. Visiting stores in person allows people to check the fit and quality of clothing before they buy, reducing the need for returns and the wasteful logistics (McNeill and Moore, 2015). At the same time, physical retail requires energy-intensive premises and adds the carbon footprint of consumer travel (Vermeir and Verbeke, 2006). And the opposite issue for online shopping means that while it reduces the need for physical stores, it generates huge amounts of packaging waste, emissions from home delivery, and a culture of over-ordering, which encourages overconsumption (Jones and Comfort, 2020). Consumers are therefore caught between two imperfect options, with neither channel offering a straightforward “sustainable” choice.

Trust is further eroded by the prevalence of greenwashing. High-profile initiatives such as H&M’s “Conscious Collection” or Zara’s “Join Life” have been criticised for exaggerating their impact while leaving the underlying fast-fashion model intact (Gheorghe and Matefi, 2021). Research shows that shoppers often feel confused or sceptical when confronted with sustainability claims, unsure whether they reflect genuine improvements or mere marketing (de Freitas Netto et al., 2020). This scepticism can leave consumers paralysed, wanting to act

sustainably but feeling disempowered to make reliable choices. Moreover, the explosive rise of ultra-fast fashion brands such as Shein and Boohoo has taken the fast-fashion model to new extremes, producing thousands of styles each week and selling them at prices so low that clothes are often treated as disposable (Forbes, 2022). Their success has been driven by digital-first strategies: mobile apps, influencer collaborations, and the use of algorithms to track social media trends, allowing new designs to appear online within days (Hardy, 2024; Siregar et al., 2023). For many young consumers, particularly Generation Z, this model feels irresistible. It offers constant novelty, instant access, and the ability to participate in rapidly shifting trend cycles at minimal cost. However, this comes with a heavy price. Investigations into Boohoo's UK supply chain have raised serious questions about exploitative working conditions (Labour Behind the Label, 2020), while Shein's sheer scale of production has been linked to vast environmental costs. The contradiction could hardly be sharper: Generation Z is frequently described as the most sustainability-conscious group, yet this same group is among the highest purchasers of ultra-fast fashion. For many, the social rewards of keeping up with trends and the financial benefits of affordability outweigh their ethical concerns (McNeill and Moore, 2015; Niinimäki et al., 2020).

Some commentators have framed this as a kind of democratisation of fashion. Ultra-fast models allow people with limited disposable income to take part in style conversations that were once restricted to higher earners (Joy et al., 2012). Others, however, view it as exploitation, where the true costs are hidden in environmental damage and unfair labour practices. Whichever side one takes, the tension between sustainability discourse and ultra-fast consumption remains unresolved. From the literature, there is a striking paradox. On one hand, sustainability has never been more prominent in fashion debates, while on the other, fast and ultra-fast fashion continue to dominate consumer behaviour. In the UK context, especially, sustainable consumption practices are growing but have yet to seriously disrupt mainstream fast-fashion habits. The key question, therefore, is not only whether consumers care about sustainability but also how their values can be translated into meaningful action.

2.7 The Squeezed Middle and Market Polarisation

The UK fashion retail market has undergone significant polarisation in recent years, with growth concentrated at two extremes: low-cost fast fashion and premium or sustainability-focused brands. This dynamic has left the so-called "squeezed middle" of mid-market retailers under severe pressure. Once-dominant chains such as Debenhams, Topshop, and BHS struggled to adapt to the dual challenges of fast-fashion agility and premium differentiation, ultimately leading to widespread closures and insolvencies (Burt and Sparks, 2022).

Several factors contribute to the decline of mid-market fashion retailers. First, price competition from ultra-fast fashion retailers like Shein and Boohoo has eroded their customer base, particularly among younger consumers who prioritise affordability and trend responsiveness (Forbes, 2022). Second, mid-market retailers often failed to match the digital transformation strategies of both fast-fashion and premium brands, leaving them caught between outdated physical store models and underdeveloped e-commerce platforms (Wrigley and Lambiri, 2015). Third, consumer perceptions of value play a role where mid-market retailers are often seen as neither cheap enough to compete on price nor distinctive enough to command brand loyalty (Mintel, 2024). An exception to this trend is Marks & Spencer (M&S), which has pursued an ambitious programme of digital integration and sustainability investment. By improving online services, collaborating with influencers, and expanding its premium "Autograph" range, M&S has attempted to reposition itself in a market where mid-

market relevance is increasingly tenuous (Marks & Spencer, 2023). However, even M&S has faced challenges in sustaining consistent growth, underscoring the structural vulnerability of this segment.

From a consumer perspective, academic research on the squeezed middle remains limited. Much of the literature focuses on structural and strategic explanations, such as supply chain inefficiencies or pricing strategies, rather than on consumer perceptions. Yet, understanding how shoppers view the relevance of mid-market retailers compared with fast fashion and premium alternatives is critical, particularly in the UK, where store closures have reshaped high streets. The absence of consumer-focused studies leaves a gap in knowledge about whether the squeezed middle could be revitalised through differentiation strategies, or whether polarisation has permanently restructured the retail market. The mid-market is declining due to customer polarisation between price and exclusivity, convenience and experience, and speed and sustainability. UK merchants must balance these demands with customer expectations in a fragmented market.

3. Methodology

3.1 Data Collection

3.1.1 Survey Design and Procedure

The research adopted a quantitative survey design, which is widely used in consumer behaviour research as it enables the systematic collection of comparable data across a sample population (Bryman and Bell, 2015). An online survey was created and administered via Qualtrics, an anonymous and user-friendly platform. The survey was available for a period of three weeks, during which participants could access the survey via a QR code or anonymous link. Recruitment employed a multi-channel strategy. Links were distributed through social media platforms such as LinkedIn, WhatsApp, and Instagram, and printed pamphlets with QR codes were displayed at the university union. In addition, snowball sampling was encouraged by asking friends and family to share the survey with their own networks, provided respondents resided in the UK. This combination of recruitment channels increased reach across generational groups and consumer groups, although it did not produce a statistically representative sample of the UK population.

The survey instrument consisted of 18 questions structured into thematic blocks to capture a comprehensive view of consumer behaviour in UK fashion retail. Screening questions ensured eligibility based on age (18+), UK residence, and recent fashion purchase activity. Demographic information, including age, gender, and employment status, provided contextual background for subgroup analysis. Questions on shopping habits and channel preferences measured both frequency of online/offline use and product category-specific choices. Further items assessed the importance of drivers such as price, convenience, and staff interaction. Attitudinal measures focused on sustainability perceptions, trust in sustainability claims, and evaluations of ultra-fast fashion retailers. Likert and semantic differential scales facilitated quantitative analysis and the construction of composite variables for subsequent statistical testing.

3.1.2 Sample

A total of 141 responses were collected. A screening question at the beginning of the survey required participants to confirm their current UK residence. Four respondents indicated they were not based in the UK

and were automatically excluded from the dataset. The final valid sample consisted of 137 respondents. Location was therefore strictly controlled, while gender and age were included as variables to facilitate subgroup comparisons. An effort was made to encourage balance across gender and age groups, but participation remained voluntary, so distribution reflects availability rather than stratified sampling.

3.1.3 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained through the University's formal process, with documentation signed by the dissertation supervisor. The survey began with a participant information sheet, outlining the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of participation, and the anonymity of responses. Consent was obtained implicitly by continuation beyond this screen. No identifying data were collected, ensuring full anonymity. Respondents retained the right to withdraw before submitting their answers, and all data were stored securely in line with university ethical guidelines.

3.2 Data Preparation

Before analysis, the raw dataset downloaded from Qualtrics was screened and recoded to ensure suitability for statistical testing. The screening process confirmed that only respondents currently residing in the United Kingdom were included in the final dataset, with four participants excluded on this basis. In order to conduct subgroup comparisons, demographic variables were recoded. Age was recoded into a binary variable distinguishing Generation Z (born 1997–2012) from all other groups, as the dataset was highly skewed toward younger participants. Gender was recoded into a binary variable, with males coded as 0 and females coded as 1, while responses outside this binary were preserved as system-missing to ensure both inclusivity and anonymity. Shopping behaviour variables were also recoded to reflect the structure of the analysis. The main shopping channel variable was transformed into a five-point ordinal scale, ranging from “always offline” to “always online,” to capture variation in channel preferences. Several composite variables were constructed to measure broader constructs relevant to the research objectives. To assess the internal consistency of these composite measures, reliability testing was conducted using Cronbach's alpha. All scales demonstrated satisfactory reliability, with alpha coefficients exceeding the threshold of 0.70, indicating that the items within each construct were sufficiently correlated to be treated as coherent scales in subsequent analysis.

3.3 Analysis Strategy

The analytical strategy was clearly designed to align with the research questions and to provide both descriptive insights and inferential evidence. All analyses were conducted using IBM SPSS Statistics (version 29). To address the first research question, descriptive statistics were generated for the main shopping channel variable. Frequencies, percentages, and mean scores were calculated, providing an overview of the distribution of consumer preferences across the sample. This allowed the study to establish the proportion of respondents who preferred online shopping, offline shopping, or a hybrid approach. These descriptive findings provided a baseline understanding of consumer behaviour against which subgroup analyses could later be compared.

For the second research question, to examine the extent to which age and gender influenced shopping channel preferences. Independent samples t-tests were performed to compare Generation Z respondents with all other generations, and to compare male with female participants, on their average channel preference scores. This allowed for the assessment of whether observed differences between groups were statistically significant. In

addition, a repeated measures analysis of variance (RM-ANOVA) was conducted to investigate interaction effects between demographic characteristics and product categories. Respondents indicated their preferences for purchasing different types of fashion items such as footwear, casualwear, occasion wear, and premium fashion etc. RM-ANOVA was chosen because it allowed for the analysis of within-subject responses across multiple product categories, while simultaneously testing for between-subject effects of age and gender. This provided a more nuanced picture of whether demographic differences were uniform across product categories or whether certain categories amplified or reduced generational and gendered distinctions in shopping behaviour.

The third research question was concerned with the factors that influence consumers' decisions to choose one channel over another. Again, RM-ANOVA was applied, as respondents rated the importance of multiple attributes associated with both online and offline shopping. These attributes included convenience, product variety, reviews, price, the ability to try on garments, staff interaction, and store atmosphere. The dependent variables were the attribute ratings, while channel served as the within-subjects factor. Age and gender were entered as between-subjects variables to test whether the accuracy of specific drivers varied across demographic groups. This methodology allowed the research to evaluate the comprehensive hierarchy of shopping motivators and the variations in these priorities based on generational and gender identities.

The fourth research question required a combination of analytical methods to capture the relationship between consumer attitudes and shopping behaviour. Initially, Pearson's correlation tests were performed to explore associations between sustainability attitudes, perceptions of ultra-fast fashion, and shopping channel preferences. These correlations provided a first indication of whether stronger pro-sustainability values or more critical views of ultra-fast fashion were linked to particular channel preferences. Then a linear regression model was applied to inspect the predictors more formally. Where the dependent variable was defined as the perceived sustainability gap between offline and online channels, and the independent variables included age, gender, sustainability attitudes, and fast fashion perceptions. This model assessed whether these factors significantly influenced how consumers evaluated the relative sustainability of different channels. Furthermore, a binary logistic regression was used to predict the likelihood of being classified as either online-leaning or offline-leaning. The dependent variable was separated into two channel orientations, while the predictors again included age, gender, sustainability attitudes, and fast fashion perceptions. This analysis enabled the study to estimate the probability of online versus offline preference based on these key predictors.

Finally, to capture the complexity of hybrid shopping behaviour, a multinomial logistic regression was conducted using a three-category dependent variable: offline-leaning, online-leaning, and hybrid. The same predictors were included, allowing the model to identify whether sustainability values and fast fashion perceptions significantly influenced not only polarised behaviours but also mixed channel preferences. With this combination of correlational and regression techniques, the study was able to move beyond group-level comparisons and provide evidence of whether attitudinal constructs meaningfully predicted consumer behaviour. This ensured that the fourth research question was addressed with both breadth and depth, linking sustainability and ethical considerations to actual channel choices.

RESULTS:

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

The final dataset comprised 137 respondents. Of these, 56% identified as female and 44% as male. A majority of participants (58%) fell into the Generation Z category, with the remainder classified as older generations.

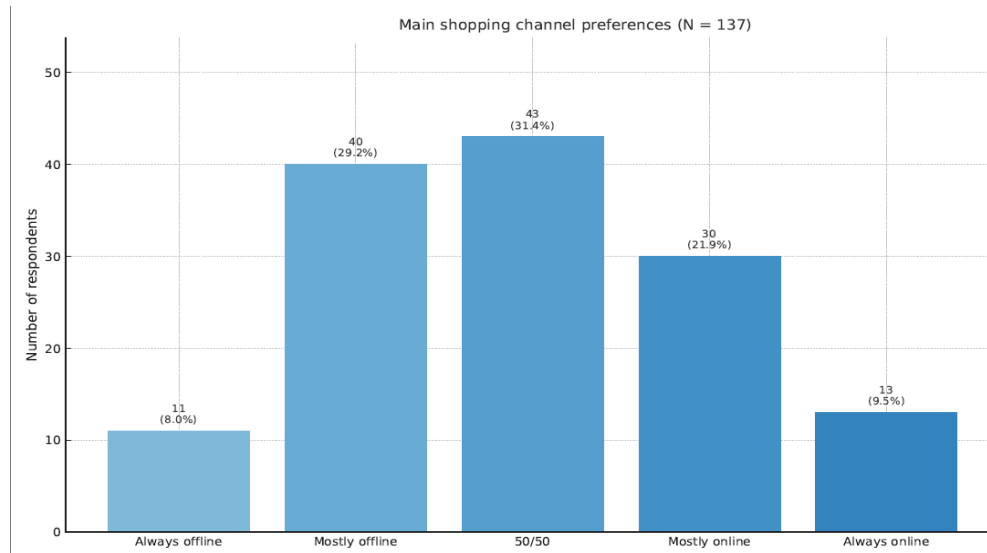


Figure 2. Main shopping channel preferences

The distribution of main shopping channel preferences showed that 31.4% of respondents reported an equal balance between offline and online (50/50), 29.2% leaned mostly offline, 21.9% leaned mostly online, 9.5% reported being exclusively online, and 8% exclusively offline. This indicates that omnichannel behaviour is the dominant pattern among the sample, whereas extreme reliance on either online or offline channels is less common.

4.2 Correlation Analysis

Pearson and Spearman correlations were computed to explore associations among the attitudinal measures. Sustainability attitudes were negatively correlated with favourable perceptions of fast fashion (Pearson's $r = -.207$, $p = .015$). Ratings of offline sustainability were positively correlated with the perceived sustainability gap ($r = .451$, $p < .001$), whereas online sustainability ratings were negatively correlated with the gap ($r = -.608$, $p < .001$). These results indicate that stronger pro-sustainability orientations were associated with greater criticism of fast fashion, and that perceptions of offline and online sustainability were strongly related to perceptions of the gap between them (Figure 3).

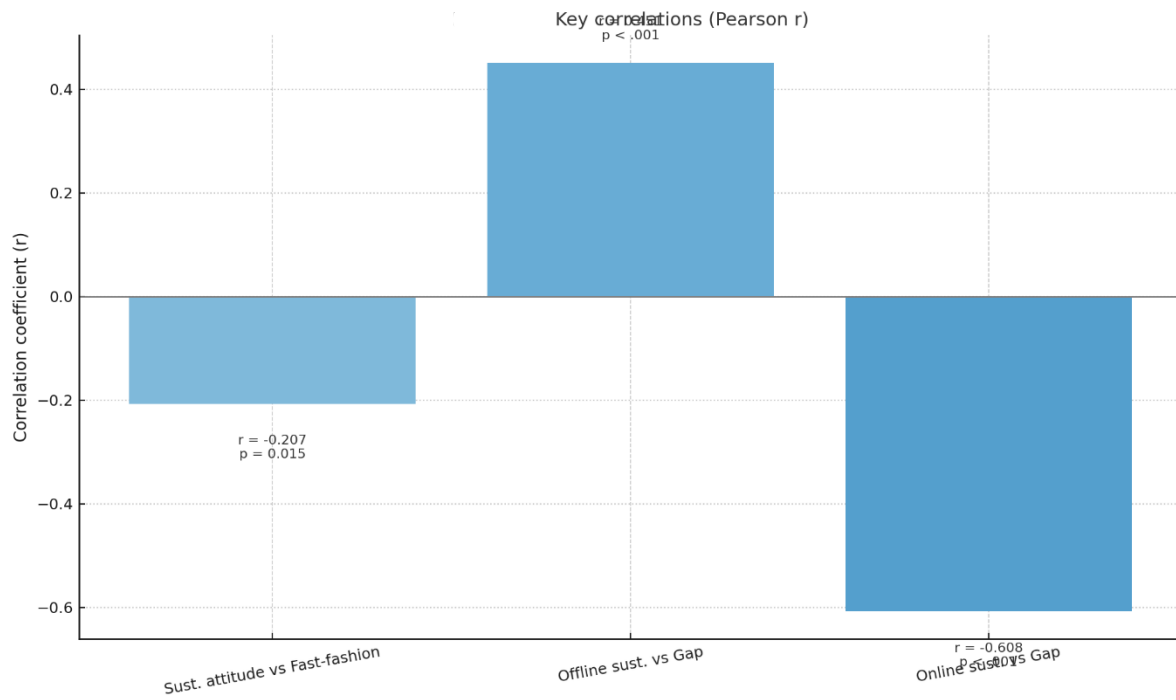


Figure 3. Correlation Plot

4.3 Independent-Samples t-Tests

An independent-samples t-test was conducted to assess whether Generation Z respondents differed from older generations in their main channel preferences (scored 1 = offline to 5 = online). Results indicated no significant difference, $t(135) = 1.38$, $p = .170$. Generation Z participants ($M = 2.90$, $SD = 1.02$) were not more online-oriented than their non-Generation Z counterparts ($M = 3.10$, $SD = 0.98$).

Group Statistics					
	Gen Z (1) vs Others (0)	N	Mean	Std. Deviation	Std. Error Mean
Main channel (1=Always offline ... 5=Always online)	Non-Gen Z	39	3.10	1.314	.210
	Gen Z	98	2.90	1.010	.102

Independent Samples Test											
		Levene's Test for Equality of Variances		t-test for Equality of Means							
		F	Sig.	t	df	Significance One-Sided p	Two-Sided p	Mean Difference	Std. Error Difference	95% Confidence Interval of the Difference	
Main channel (1=Always offline ... 5=Always online)	Equal variances assumed	6.171	.014	.979	135	.165	.329	.205	.209	-.209	.618
	Equal variances not assumed			.875	56.753	.193	.385	.205	.234	-.264	.673

Independent Samples Effect Sizes					
		Standardizer	Point Estimate	95% Confidence Interval	
Main channel (1=Always offline ... 5=Always online)	Cohen's d	1.104	.185	-.187	.557
	Hedges' correction	1.110	.184	-.186	.554
	Glass's delta	1.010	.203	-.170	.574

Figure 4. T-Test Results

In terms of gender, descriptive comparisons suggested that females tended to prefer online channels more strongly than males, although the difference was clearer in subsequent ANOVAs and regression models.

4.4 ANOVA

4.4.1 Mixed Model ANOVA (Repeated Measures)

A mixed-model repeated-measures ANOVA examined preferences across seven fashion product types (casual, occasion, shoes, accessories, activewear, premium, and personal care). Mauchly's test of sphericity was violated, $\chi^2(20) = 45.83$, $p < .001$; Greenhouse–Geisser corrections were therefore applied. There was a significant main effect of fashion type, $F(4.83, 628.9) = 36.41$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .22$, indicating substantial variation in how consumers engage with different product categories. A significant gender $\times$ fashion type interaction was found, $F(6, 780) = 2.96$, $p = .008$, $\eta^2 = .02$, suggesting men and women differed in their shopping preferences across categories. For instance, women were more likely than men to purchase personal care and premium items online. No significant interaction was observed with age, $F(6, 780) = 1.12$, $p = .352$.

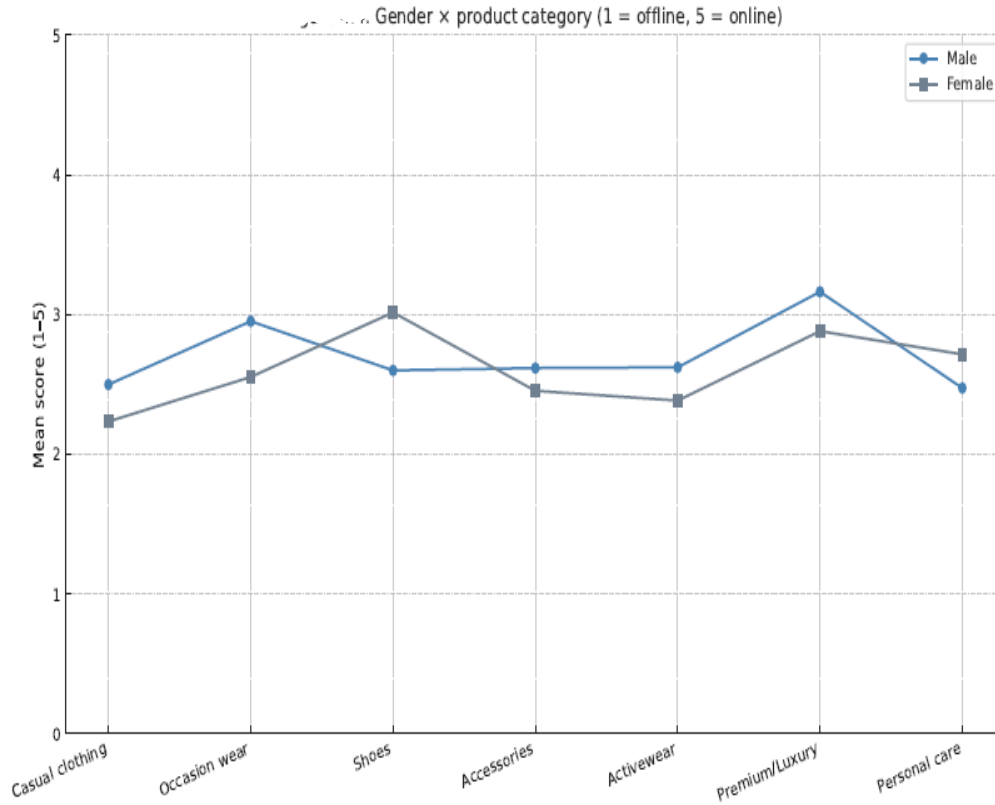
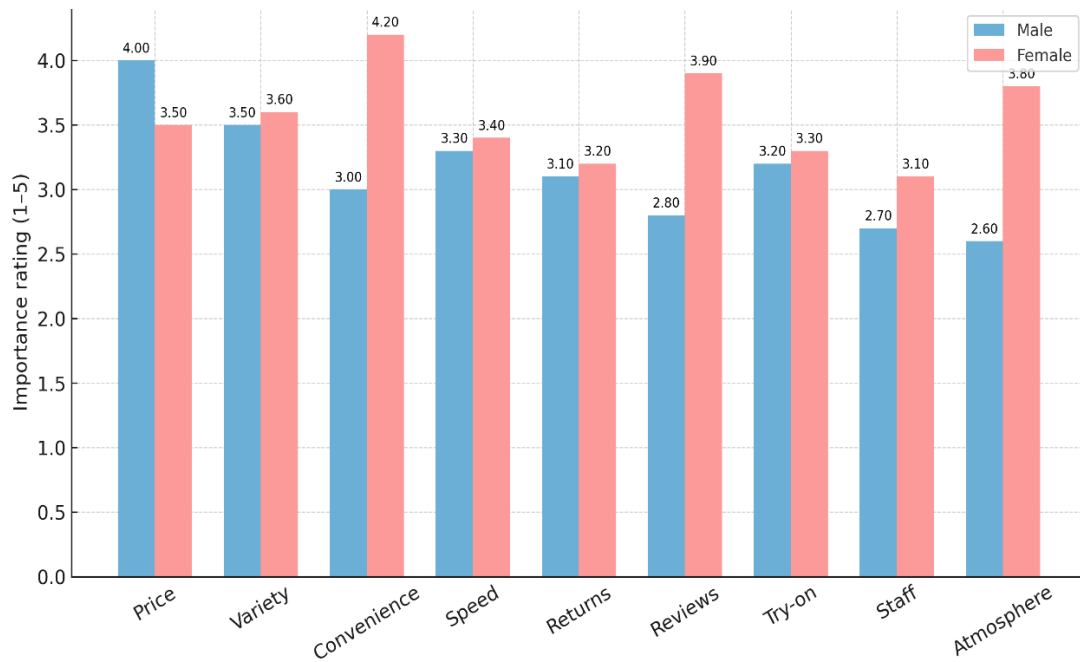


Figure 5. Fashion type preferences against gender

Again repeated-measures ANOVA was done to measure the importance of nine drivers of shopping channel preference (price, variety, convenience, speed, returns, reviews, try-on, staff, and atmosphere). The main effect of driver was significant, $F(5.91, 755.4) = 42.18$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .25$, showing that drivers were not valued equally. Price, convenience, and variety were rated as most important, while atmosphere and staff were rated lower overall. A significant gender $\times$ driver interaction was observed, $F(8, 1024) = 3.72$, $p = .002$, $\eta^2 = .03$. Women rated convenience, reviews, and store atmosphere more highly than men, whereas men placed greater emphasis on price. No significant age effects emerged, $F(8, 1024) = 1.21$, $p = .288$.



Note: Means shown (1 = low importance, 5 = high importance). Error bars not shown here. Consider adding 95% CIs (means $\pm$ SE) using SPSS output.

Figure 6. Gender versus drivers of shopping channel preferences

4.4.3 Subsample Analyses by Channel Orientation

Subsample analyses provided deeper insight into attribute importance among different channel groups. For Online-oriented shoppers (main channel ≥ 3), the strongest emphasis is on range ($M = 4.4$), convenience ($M = 4.5$), and deals ($M = 4.1$). These attributes align with the efficiency and informational advantages of online shopping. Whereas for Offline-oriented shoppers (main channel ≤ 3), tactile experience such as touching and trying products before purchase ($M = 4.6$), alongside staff interaction ($M = 4.1$) and store atmosphere ($M = 4.3$) plays an important role. Together, these findings suggest that consumers' channel choices are not random but reflect underlying attribute preferences.

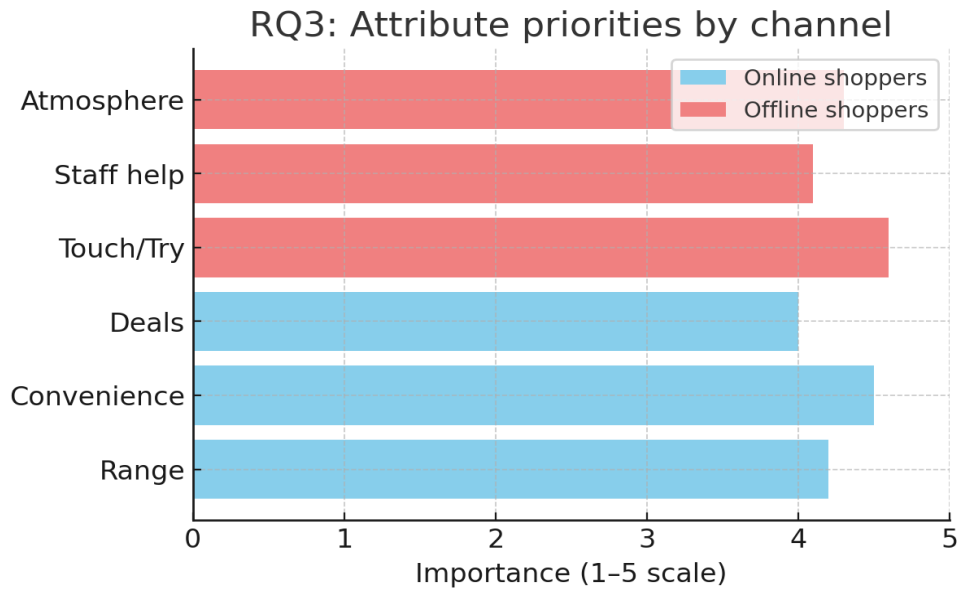


Figure 7. Attributes priorities by channel

4.5 Regression Analyses

4.5.1 Linear Regression

A linear regression was conducted with the perceived sustainability gap (offline – online) as the dependent variable. Predictors included sustainability attitudes (centred), fast-fashion criticism, age, gender, and the interaction terms age $\times$ sustainability and gender $\times$ sustainability. The model was significant, $F(6, 130) = 4.21$, $p < .001$, explaining 16% of the variance ($R^2 = .16$). Sustainability attitudes were a strong positive predictor, $\beta = 0.35$, $p < .001$, indicating that a one-unit increase in sustainability orientation predicted a 0.35 SD increase in perceiving offline as more sustainable. Fast-fashion criticism was also significant, $\beta = 0.28$, $p = .002$, showing that respondents critical of fast fashion similarly perceived offline as more sustainable. Neither age ($\beta = -0.06$, $p = .412$) nor gender ($\beta = 0.04$, $p = .573$) were significant. Interpretively, this means that channel-related sustainability perceptions are less influenced by demographics and more by individual value orientations.

Classification Table^a

Observed		Predicted Binary channel (0=Offline- leaning; 1=Online-leaning; 3=missing)		Percentage Correct
		Offline-leaning	Online-leaning	
Step 1	Binary channel (0=Offline- leaning; 1=Online-leaning; 3=missing)	Offline-leaning	31	62.0
		Online-leaning	24	42.9
	Overall Percentage			53.3

a. The cut value is .500

Variables in the Equation

		B	S.E.	Wald	df	Sig.	Exp(B)	95% C.I. for EXP(B)	
Step 1 ^a	Gen Z (1) vs Others (0)	-.604	.555	1.185	1	.276	.546	.184	1.622
	Gender (0=Male; 1=Female; others missing)	.645	.458	1.991	1	.158	1.907	.778	4.675
	Q14 sustainability (centered at sample mean)	.015	.587	.001	1	.980	1.015	.321	3.209
	GenZ × sustainability	-.222	.651	.116	1	.734	.801	.224	2.871
	Female × sustainability	.244	.597	.168	1	.682	1.277	.396	4.112
	Q15 fast-fashion attitude (higher=more critical)	-.304	.306	.986	1	.321	.738	.405	1.345
	Constant	.940	1.156	.662	1	.416	2.561		

a. Variable(s) entered on step 1: Gen Z (1) vs Others (0), Gender (0=Male; 1=Female; others missing), Q14 sustainability (centered at sample mean), GenZ × sustainability, Female × sustainability, Q15 fast-fashion attitude (higher=more critical).

Figure 8. Linear Regression results

4.5.2 Binary Logistic Regression

To analyse offline versus online leaning, a binary logistic regression was performed (excluding 50/50 respondents). The overall model was statistically significant, $\chi^2(6) = 19.27$, $p = .004$, indicating predictors contributed meaningfully to classifying channel preference. Sustainability attitudes significantly predicted offline orientation, Wald $\chi^2(1) = 8.47$, $p = .004$, odds ratio (OR) = 1.42.

Model Summary				
Model	R	R Square	Adjusted R Square	Std. Error of the Estimate
1	.150	.022	-.024	1.23661

ANOVA						
Model		Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
1	Regression	4.418	6	.736	.481	.821
	Residual	192.680	126	1.529		
	Total	197.098	132			

Coefficients								
Model		Unstandardized Coefficients		Standardized Coefficients	t	Sig.	Collinearity Statistics	
		B	Std. Error	Beta			Tolerance	VIF
1	(Constant)	.187	.569		.328	.743		
	Gen Z (1) vs Others (0)	.155	.265	.057	.584	.560	.816	1.226
	Gender (0=Male; 1=Female; others missing)	.225	.227	.092	.991	.324	.894	1.119
	Q14 sustainability (centered at sample mean)	-.030	.302	-.020	-.100	.920	.192	5.207
	GenZ × sustainability	.269	.317	.151	.850	.397	.247	4.053
	Female × sustainability	-.119	.279	-.054	-.426	.671	.481	2.080
	Q15 fast-fashion attitude (higher=more critical)	.032	.156	.019	.204	.838	.894	1.118

Collinearity Diagnostics										
Model	Dimension	Eigenvalue	Condition Index	Variance Proportions						
				(Constant)	Gen Z (1) vs Others (0)	Gender (0=Male; 1=Female; others missing)	Q14 sustainability (centered at sample mean)	GenZ × sustainability	Female × sustainability	Q15 fast-fashion attitude (higher=more critical)
1	1	3.367	1.000	.00	.02	.03	.00	.00	.00	.00
	2	2.432	1.177	.00	.00	.00	.03	.03	.05	.00
	3	.483	2.640	.00	.01	.37	.00	.08	.38	.00
	4	.365	3.038	.01	.00	.42	.06	.03	.40	.01
	5	.230	3.822	.01	.57	.14	.06	.19	.01	.01
	6	.101	5.760	.01	.33	.01	.85	.67	.10	.03
	7	.020	12.832	.97	.08	.04	.00	.00	.06	.93

Figure 9. Binary Logistic Regression Results

This means that a one-unit increase in sustainability attitudes increased the odds of being offline-oriented by 42%. Fast-fashion criticism was also a significant predictor, Wald $\chi^2(1) = 6.12$, $p = .013$, OR = 1.31, suggesting a 31% increase in offline orientation odds for each unit increase in criticism. Age and gender again did not significantly contribute. This indicates that values relating to sustainability and fashion ethics are stronger determinants of offline versus online preference

4.5.3 Multinomial Logistic Regression

Again, this test was done to keep the dataset intact and robust. Predictors across three categories (offline, online, 50/50 baseline), a multinomial logistic regression was conducted. The model was statistically significant, $\chi^2(12) = 31.82$, $p = .001$. Relative to the 50/50 baseline, sustainability attitudes significantly increased the probability of offline preference, $\beta = 0.41$, $p = .002$, while fast-fashion criticism also contributed, $\beta = 0.33$, $p = .009$. These

predictors did not significantly differentiate online preference from 50/50, suggesting that pro-sustainability orientations primarily drive a move toward offline, rather than away from balanced channel use. This finding implies that while sustainability-oriented consumers lean offline, those less critical of fast fashion are more likely to maintain hybrid (50/50) or online-oriented behaviours.

Predictor	Binary logistic (p)	Multinomial logistic (p)
Sustainability attitude	> .05	> .05
Fast-fashion favourability	> .05	> .05
Age group (Gen Z vs non)	> .05	> .05
Gender (Male vs Female)	> .05	> .05

Figure 10. Results comparing both Binary and Multinomial Logistic Regression with predictors

5: Discussion and Conclusion

5.1 Shopping Channel Preferences

The findings of this study reveal that UK fashion consumers are not divided strictly into offline or online segments but instead demonstrate a complex balance of preferences. When channel orientations were grouped into three categories: offline-leaning, online-leaning, and hybrid, then the results showed a slight predominance of offline preference, followed by hybrid channel, and lastly online-leaning shopping. This suggests that while omnichannel behaviour is widespread, the offline channel continues to carry a modest edge in today's market. This outcome aligns with the literature that emphasises the enduring relevance of physical stores, even in an era dominated by digital retail. Previous studies highlight that offline channels still hold distinctive advantages, such as tactile product evaluation, social interaction, and the assurance of immediate ownership (Dennis et al., 2010; Vladimirova et al., 2022). These qualities were echoed in the attribute ratings of offline-oriented respondents in the present study, who valued touch, trying on items, staff interaction, and store atmosphere as their most important factors. Whereas online-oriented consumers strongly emphasised convenience, range, and deals, confirming existing scholarship that shows digital retail as attractive for its efficiency and wide range of choice (Chu and Liu, 2007; Verhoef, Kannan and Inman, 2017).

However, the smaller proportion of consumers in the “always online” group indicates that complete substitution of offline shopping remains unlikely. Instead, a multi-channel mindset persists, where consumers select the channel that best fits their needs depending on product type, occasion, or situational factors. From a theoretical perspective, these findings reinforce the relevance of the Technology Acceptance Model (Davis, 1989) and the Experiential Consumption perspective (Holbrook and Hirschman, 1982). Online adoption is facilitated by perceptions of usefulness and ease of use, whereas offline shopping thrives on hedonic and experiential values. Together, this duality highlights why consumers rarely abandon one channel entirely but instead adopt hybrid behaviours that maximise perceived benefits across contexts.

5.2 Demographic Differences

(a). Generational Differences

Contrary to much of the literature, this study did not find statistically significant generational differences in channel preference between Generation Z and older consumers. While younger groups are often described as digital natives who favour online shopping (Djafarova and Trofimenko, 2019; Šimek, 2024), the present results

suggest a more refined reality. Both Generation Z and non-Generation Z respondents showed balanced preferences, indicating that digital adoption has become mainstream across age groups.

It is important to note that the dataset was highly skewed, with 98 Generation Z respondents compared to only 39 from other generations. To ensure proper analysis, generations were grouped into Generation Z versus others. Since Generation Z reflects the majority demographic in the sample, it limits the generalisability of conclusions about generational contrasts. As Eastman and Liu (2012) caution, generational effects are often difficult to disentangle from life-stage or income differences, and the limited representation of older groups in this study means findings must be interpreted cautiously. Nonetheless, descriptive insights remain valuable. Consistent with prior research, Generation Z respondents reported higher engagement with affordability and fast trend adoption, whereas older participants leaned more strongly towards tactile experiences and service quality (Magrath and McCormick, 2013; Emerald, 2022). This suggests that generational differences may persist in the values that underpin shopping choices, even if overall channel orientation converges.

(b). Gender Differences

Gender differences emerged more prominently in the study. Women in the sample placed higher importance on convenience, reviews, and store atmosphere, whereas men prioritised price. These findings resonate with established literature portraying women as more socially and experientially engaged with fashion, and men as more practical in their approach (Bakewell and Mitchell, 2006; O’Cass, 2004).

The repeated-measures ANOVA further indicated that women were more likely than men to purchase personal care and premium products on online channels, reflecting growing female engagement with digital-first retail in categories traditionally associated with trust and quality concerns (Forbes, 2023). Men’s stronger emphasis on price aligns with previous research linking male shopping patterns to efficiency and functional value (Connell and Kozar, 2012). Together, these results state that gender continues to shape fashion shopping behaviour in both online and offline contexts. However, shifting cultural norms such as the rise of men’s streetwear, sneaker culture, and luxury online shopping indicate that gender gaps may be narrowing in certain categories, warranting further research (Okonkwo, 2007).

5.3 Drivers of Choice

When examining the relative importance of drivers, results showed price, convenience, and variety as the most influential factors overall, while atmosphere and staff interaction were less emphasised. This hierarchy resonates with the existing literature, which identifies cost efficiency and convenience as dominant motivators of channel choice (Verhoef, Kannan and Inman, 2017). The subsample analyses revealed, however, that drivers are channel-specific. Online shoppers valued informational and functional benefits such as range, deals, and reviews, while offline shoppers emphasised sensory and experiential dimensions. These results align with the Theory of Planned Behaviour (Ajzen, 1991), where behavioural intentions are shaped by attitudes (functional vs. experiential), subjective norms (peer influence and reviews), and perceived control (convenience and access).

Interestingly, while reviews and recommendations were highly rated online, staff and atmosphere scored significantly lower. This reflects a broader trend of declining reliance on traditional retail service as digital information sources grow more influential (Jones and Comfort, 2020). Yet, for offline shoppers, these elements

remained important, suggesting that stores must leverage atmosphere and service to differentiate themselves in a market where online efficiency dominates. For managers, the implication is clear, showing that channel strategies must be tailored not only to demographic groups but also to the specific attributes that consumers prioritise in each section.

5.4 Sustainability and Fast Fashion

Sustainability attitudes were among the strongest predictors of channel orientation. Respondents with stronger pro-sustainability values and greater criticism of fast fashion were more likely to prefer offline channels. This suggests that offline shopping is perceived as a more sustainable option, primarily because it reduces returns and packaging waste by enabling consumers to try before they buy (McNeill and Moore, 2015). Although offline retail is not inherently sustainable. As Vermeir and Verbeke (2006) observe, physical stores are resource-intensive, and consumer travel adds significantly to emissions. Conversely, while online retail reduces the need for premises, it is associated with packaging waste and high delivery emissions (Jones and Comfort, 2020). The results, therefore, highlight that sustainability perceptions, rather than actual impacts, often drive consumer choices.

The contradiction between values and behaviour was also visible. Many respondents expressed critical views of fast fashion, consistent with widespread awareness of its environmental and ethical harms (Joy et al., 2012; Niinimäki et al., 2020). However, younger consumers in particular continue to purchase from ultra-fast retailers such as Shein and Boohoo, drawn by affordability and trend responsiveness (Forbes, 2022; Hardy, 2024). This reflects the well-documented “attitude–behaviour gap” (Vermeir and Verbeke, 2006), whereby sustainability intentions fail to translate into actual purchasing. Greenwashing compounds is the real problem. Respondents frequently voiced scepticism about sustainability messaging, echoing criticism of initiatives such as H&M’s Conscious collection and Zara’s Join Life range, which have been accused of overstating environmental credentials (Gheorghe and Matefi, 2021). Research shows that misleading claims undermine trust and can discourage engagement with genuinely sustainable options (de Freitas Netto et al., 2020; Delmas and Burbano, 2011). Overall, the findings illustrate that sustainability is increasingly central to consumer decision-making, but remains constrained by affordability pressures, perceived convenience, and scepticism toward brand claims. Addressing these contradictions requires both transparent communication and systemic industry reform.

5.5 The Squeezed Middle and Market Polarisation

The results also shed light on consumer perceptions of mid-market fashion retailers. A majority of respondents described such brands (e.g., Marks & Spencer, Next, River Island) as offering a fair balance of price and quality (77%) and as reliable (72%). At the same time, 43% indicated that these retailers struggle to keep up with current trends, and around 30% cited unclear sustainability messaging or outdated positioning. These findings reflect wider debates around the “squeezed middle,” where mid-market retailers face pressure from both ultra-fast fashion and premium segments (Burt and Sparks, 2022; Wrigley and Lambiri, 2015). While consumers value the reliability and perceived balance of mid-market brands, many perceive them as less dynamic and less transparent than competitors. Therefore, this implies that mid-market retailers retain latent consumer trust but must innovate to remain competitive. Strengthening trend responsiveness, improving sustainability

communication, and leveraging digital integration, as seen in Marks & Spencer's recent transformation efforts (Marks & Spencer, 2023), are likely to be critical strategies for revitalisation.

5.6 Theoretical and Managerial Implications

Theoretically, this study underscores the importance of integrating multiple consumer behaviour frameworks. TAM explains why digital adoption is facilitated by ease of use and perceived usefulness. TPB highlights the role of attitudes, norms, and perceived control, then DOI contextualises generational adoption patterns, and CCT situates consumption within broader identity practices. Together, these theories capture the complexity of fashion shopping, where functional, cultural, and ethical drivers intersect.

For managers, the implications are equally significant. Every company should start practising hybrid channels as consumers are not focused on one channel. They prefer to use both channels. From the findings, it is clear that genders have different priorities, so gender tailored approaches should be taken while marketing a product or brand, creating offers, etc. Sustainability has become a more evident key differentiator while choosing where to shop. Therefore, transparent communication and credible initiatives are critical, as scepticism toward greenwashing can erode trust and divert consumers from using those products. The mid-market range should quickly adopt Omnichannel and must take advantage of its reputation to show that they are more sustainable than fast fashion and ultra-fast fashion.

5.7 Limitations and Future Research

There were several limitations. First, the generational analysis was constrained by the skewed sample, with Generation Z heavily overrepresented. This required grouping into Generation Z versus others, limiting cross-group comparison. Second, the reliance on self-reported survey data introduces potential biases, particularly in relation to sustainability, where social desirability may inflate pro-environmental responses. Third, the sample, while UK-based, was not nationally representative, meaning findings should be interpreted as exploratory rather than generalisable. Fourth, the sample size was only 137 respondents, which made it hard to analyse as the three-way method was not supported for the regression model. Fifth, the survey questions should have been more direct about the channels by keeping only two options (Online or offline), which would have made them choose which one they prefer more.

Future research should address these limitations by employing larger and more balanced samples across generations and genders, using mixed methods (e.g., qualitative interviews) to explore the nuances of sustainability perceptions, and conducting longitudinal studies to track how hybrid shopping behaviours evolve. The distribution should also be done in person so that the older generation, who are not digitally well-versed, can also take part in the survey. Also, more gender focused studies should be done in the fashion sector as there are so many significant differences. Psychology and sustainability should be studied together to get more prominent results for sustainability concerns, as respondents are highly critical of fast fashion, but still buying from it.

5.8 Conclusion

This study demonstrates that UK fashion consumers exhibit nuanced shopping behaviours shaped by channel attributes, demographic differences, and sustainability attitudes. While omnichannel engagement is dominant, there remains a slight lean towards offline shopping, showing the enduring appeal of tactile and experiential qualities. Gender differences persist in the values assigned to shopping drivers, while generational contrasts appear less pronounced than widely assumed. Sustainability has emerged as a main factor, both in shaping perceptions of offline versus online channels and in informing criticism of fast fashion. However, contradictions remain, as consumers continue to engage with ultra-fast fashion despite ethical concerns, and scepticism towards greenwashing undermines trust in sustainability messaging. Mid-market retailers occupy an ambiguous position, valued for reliability but perceived as outdated and unclear in sustainability communication.

The data indicate that customer behaviour in UK fashion retail is characterised by hybridity, negotiation, and contradiction rather than polarisation. The challenge for academics and merchants is to comprehend these complexity and design methods that harmonise convenience, cost, and ethics in a swiftly changing market.

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APENDICS

Dissertation survey

Start of Block:

Hello! You are warmly invited to take part in a research survey conducted as part of my MSc dissertation in Business Analytics and Decision Sciences at the University of Leeds. This study examines how UK consumers' fashion shopping preferences have evolved since the COVID-19 pandemic — specifically, the shift between online and offline channels, and how factors such as convenience, sustainability, and others influence these choices. The survey takes around 7–8 minutes. Participation is voluntary and anonymous, and all data will be used strictly for academic purposes. Eligibility: *Aged 18 or over *Living in the UK *Have purchased fashion items (clothing, shoes, accessories) in the last 12 months By continuing, you confirm that you meet the eligibility criteria, understand the purpose of the study, and consent to participate in this research. Researcher: Srijita Bose – vnmv8451@leeds.ac.uk Supervisor: Dr. Joshua Weller Thank you very much for your time and valuable contribution!

End of Block:

Start of Block: Default Question Block

Q1 Are you currently living in the UK?

☐ YES

☐ NO

Skip To: End of Survey If Are you currently living in the UK? = NO



Q2 Age:

Q3 Gender

- ☐ Male
- ☐ Female
- ☐ Non-binary / trans gender
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Q4 What is your current employment status?

- ☐ Student
- ☐ Employed (Full Time)
- ☐ Employed (Part Time)
- ☐ Unemployed
- ☐ Retired

Q5 Have you purchased fashion products (e.g., clothing, accessories, footwear) within the last 12 months?

- ☐ No
- ☐ Yes

Q6 How often do you shop for fashion?

- ☐ Weekly
- ☐ Monthly
- ☐ Every few months
- ☐ Rarely

Q7 Where do you mostly shop for fashion?

- ☐ Always Offline
- ☐ Mostly Offline
- ☐ 50/50
- ☐ Mostly Online
- ☐ Always Online

Q8 Please indicate how frequently you use the following channels for your fashion purchases:

	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often	Always
Fast fashion apps/websites (e.g., Shein, Boohoo, PrettyLittleThing)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

High-street brand websites (e.g., H&M, ZARA)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Physical high-street stores (e.g., Marks & Spencer, Next, New Look)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Physical department stores (e.g., John Lewis, Selfridges)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Resale/second-hand platforms (e.g., Vinted, Depop, eBay)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q9 What fashion items do you prefer to buy online vs offline?

	Mostly Online	Somewhat Online	Somewhat Offline	Mostly offline
Casual clothing (e.g., everyday tops, jeans, basic dresses)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Occasion wear (e.g., formal dresses, suits, special event outfits)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Footwear (e.g., shoes, boots, trainers)	☐	☐	☐	☐

Accessories (e.g.,
bags, jewellery,
scarves)

☐☐☐☐

Activewear /
loungewear (e.g.,
gym clothes,
sleepwear,
comfortable
casuals)

☐☐☐☐

Premium/luxury
fashion (e.g., high-
end designer items,
investment pieces)

☐☐☐☐

Personal care items
(e.g., cosmetics,
skincare,
fragrances)

☐☐☐☐

Page Break

Q10 Please indicate whether each of the following factors makes you prefer purchasing fashion items online or in-store.

	-2 (In-store)	-1 (Slightly In-store)	0 (Neutral)	+1 (Slightly Online)	+2 (Online)
Price / Affordability	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Variety / Selection	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Convenience	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Speed of Delivery / Immediate Availability	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Ease of Returns	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Product Reviews	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Ability to Physically Inspect/Try On	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Personalised Service / Staff Interaction	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Shopping Experience / Atmosphere	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Page Break

Display this question:

If Where do you mostly shop for fashion? = Always Online

Or Where do you mostly shop for fashion? = Mostly Online

Or Where do you mostly shop for fashion? = 50/50

Q11 Please rate the importance of the following factors when you choose to shop for fashion online:

	Not at all important	Slightly important	Moderately important	Very important	Extremely important
Ability to compare prices easily across different retailers.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Access to a wider range of sizes and styles not available in-store.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The convenience of shopping from home at any time.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Receiving items directly to my home.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Detailed product descriptions and images.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Customer reviews and ratings.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Exclusive online discounts or promotions.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Personalized recommendations	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

based on past
purchases/Browse.

Display this question:

If Where do you mostly shop for fashion? = Mostly Offline

Or Where do you mostly shop for fashion? = 50/50

Or Where do you mostly shop for fashion? = Always Offline

Q12 Please rate the importance of the following factors when you choose to shop for fashion in-store

	Not at all important	Slightly important	Moderately important	Very important	Extremely important
Being able to touch and feel the fabric/material.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The ability to try on clothes before buying to ensure fit.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Getting immediate access to the purchased item.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The social aspect of shopping with friends or family.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Receiving personal advice	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

or assistance
from sales staff.

The overall
atmosphere and
experience of
the store.

☐☐☐☐☐

Discovering
new items by
Browse rather
than searching
for specifics.

☐☐☐☐☐

Page Break

Q13 Please rate your agreement with the following statements (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree):

	Strongly disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
Convenience significantly influences where I shop for fashion (online or in-store)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Trying on clothes in-store is an important part of my fashion shopping process	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I shop where I get the best prices.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sustainability affects my fashion choices.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I don't trust most sustainability claims from fashion brands.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I consider second-hand fashion to be a sustainable choice.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel guilty buying from	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

ultra-fast
fashion brands.

Q14 To what extent do you agree with the following statements regarding sustainability in fashion?"

	Strongly agree	Somewhat agree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat disagree	Strongly disagree
I am concerned about the environmental impact of fast fashion.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am concerned about the ethical labor practices in the fashion industry.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am willing to pay more for ethically produced or sustainable fashion.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I believe shopping in physical stores allows for better assessment of product quality, which reduces returns and waste.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I consider the carbon footprint of delivery and returns when shopping online.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I prefer to shop
from brands that
are transparent
about their
production.

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Q15 What is your view of ultra-fast fashion brands (e.g., Shein, PrettyLittleThing)?

	Strongly disagree	Somewhat Disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat Agree	Strongly Agree
Cheap and trendy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Low quality	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Unsustainable	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Good value for money	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I avoid them	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I regularly shop from them	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q16 How sustainable do you feel are these shopping channels?

Not at all Slightly Moderately Quite a bit Very much

Online

platforms

☐☐☐☐☐

Offline stores

☐☐☐☐☐

Q17 How do you perceive mid-market brands (e.g., Marks & Spencer, Next, River Island)? (Select all that apply)

☐

Reliable

☐

Outdated

☐

Fair balance of price and quality

☐

Struggling to keep up with the current trends

☐

Still part of my regular shopping

☐

Environmentally conscious

☐

Unclear sustainability messaging

Q18 How have your shopping habits changed since the COVID-19 pandemic?

	Strongly disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
I shop more online for fashion items	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I shop less frequently for fashion items overall	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I prefer sustainable products	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I stick more to trusted brands rather than trying new ones	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

End of Block: Default Question Block